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SRI LANKA TOURISM DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY (SLTDA)

SUSTAINABLE TOURISM & ECO-FRIENDLY GUIDELINES FOR TOURS & SAFARIS

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1. SINGLE-USE PLASTIC BANS & WASTE MANAGEMENT DIRECTIVES

- Single-Use Plastic Ban:

The use of single-use polythene bags, plastic lunch sheets, plastic straws, plastic cutlery, and disposable cups/trays is strictly prohibited in all national parks, nature reserves, and protected heritage sites.

- Water Bottles:

Tour operators and transport units are strongly encouraged to provide glass water bottles or reusable steel containers instead of single-use PET plastic bottles.

- Waste Disposal Rule:

"Pack it in, Pack it out." All non-biodegradable waste generated during tours, safaris, and hikes must be carried back out by the tour group.

- Garbage Sorting:

Tour accommodations and vehicles must maintain separate bins for recyclable waste (glass, metal, hard plastics) and organic waste.

2. WILDLIFE SAFARI & PROTECTED AREA CONDUCT

- No Single-Use Plastics in Parks:

Visitors entering Wildlife Parks (Yala, Wilpattu, Udawalawe, Minneriya, etc.) will be checked at entry gates. Single-use plastic wrappers, bags, and bottles are completely banned inside park boundaries.

- Distance & Speed Limits:

Safari jeeps must maintain a speed limit of under 25 km/h inside national parks and keep a minimum distance of 15–20 meters from wild animals (elephants, leopards, bears).

- Feeding & Noise Restrictions:

Feeding wild animals or playing loud audio/music inside wildlife and nature zones is strictly prohibited and subject to immediate eviction and fines.

- Off-Road Driving:

Vehicles must strictly remain on designated tracks and trails. Driving off-track into animal habitats is illegal.

3. HERITAGE & CULTURAL SITES (CULTURAL TRIANGLE)

- Conservation Guidelines:

Tourists must adhere to respectful dress codes (covered shoulders and knees) at sacred and cultural heritage sites (Sigiriya, Anuradhapura, Polonnaruwa, Dambulla, Kandy).

- Littering Fines:

Spot fines are enforced by local authorities and the Central Cultural Fund (CCF) for littering or damaging ancient ruins and structures.

- Footwear Policy:

Shoes and headwear must be removed before entering active temple yards and shrine rooms.

4. ENERGY & SUSTAINABILITY RECOMMENDATIONS FOR TOUR OPERATORS

- Carbon Footprint Reduction:

Encouragement of shared eco-transfers, hybrid/electric safari vehicles, and optimized travel itineraries to minimize fuel consumption.

- Local Community Benefit:

Tour itineraries should prioritize local guides, local community-driven restaurants, and ethical eco-lodges certified under the National Sustainable Tourism Certification Scheme (NSTCS).

5. ECO-FRIENDLY VEHICLE RULES

- Electric & Hybrid Vehicles:

Priority entry passes awarded to zero-emission and low-emission safari vehicles.

- Engine Noise Standards:

Safari jeeps must maintain noise levels below 60 dB while inside park zones. Idle engines must be switched off during animal sightings.

6. COMMUNITY & LOCAL GUIDE DIRECTIVES

- Mandatory local guide:

Every group must engage a certified local track guide from the park entrance to ensure safety and policy compliance.

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